

Allen put down his work and left the office, telling the receptionist he would be back in an hour or so. He entered the bank and asked if he could see Gary Barnes, who was the vice president of the loan department. In a short while he was directed to the banker's office.

"Allen, sit down, won't you?" the banker said politely. He walked over and closed the door to his office. "You have some severe financial problems, don't you?" he asked.

"Well, we do have some temporary problems, Gary," Allen replied. "But I'll be able to clear them up when the next bonus comes."

"You need to face reality," Gary said as he opened the file on his desk. "I took the liberty of checking into your recent credit history. You're behind on everything, even your utility payments."

"It seems that there's not enough money to make it every month," Allen explained. "But I'll be a partner in the firm in a few months, and my income will increase substantially then. Can't you extend the second mortgage? I would only need a few thousand dollars more to make it until then."

"No, I absolutely will not. It's not more money you need, and another consolidation loan won't help. You're simply digging yourself a bigger pit. You're living beyond your means and using loans to make up the difference. And you'll just continue to do so, no matter how much you make. I did you a disservice by giving you the first consolidation loan on your house. You're worse off now than you were then."

Allen slumped down in his chair. He wanted to argue with the banker, but he knew that he was telling the truth. They were worse off now, and there seemed to be no end to the flood of money going out. With a new baby, Sherry wasn't in a position to work, so it was all up to him.

"What can I do?" Allen asked in a subdued tone. "If you foreclose on my home, I may lose my job."